

Opera 7 was released in early 2003 and featured a brand new rendering engine called Presto. This engine enhanced and expanded its support for standards and included W3C DOM and the Small Screen Rendering technique for handheld devices. The interface was redone entirely with a custom cross-platform skinning system which significantly reduced resource usage, keyboard shortcuts, mouse gestures, menus and toolbars. Other new features that were included in this release were features such as FastForward, Notes and Slideshow, which made the user experience even more enjoyable. A new news and mail client called M2 was introduced in this version as well as a RSS news reader and an IRC chat client.

Opera 8 was released in early 2005 and is currently in version 8.0.1. The major reason for Opera being accepted publicly was not because of its compliance in standards with other browsers, but because of the non-standard browsing enhancements that were absent in its competitors. It is light weight and has its own cult of fans. It has innovative features and is one of the most used browsers on mobile devices.

Currently, Opera has started making inroads in other embedded systems platforms as well. Opera's market share is starting to make a bit of a dent with users sticking to this alternative browser rather than using Internet Explorer or Netscape. Plus, many of Opera's innovative features are finding their way into other browsers as well. One of them is FireFox, the browser that we will be talking about next.